

Did You Know...? Competitive Hobbyhorsing

Name: _____

Date: _____

The facts (from a Metro Explores video)

Hobbyhorsing is a real competitive sport – riders perform dressage and show-jumping routines with a stick topped by a decorated horse head, no real horse involved. It started in Finland in the early 2000s and has since spread worldwide, including the UK, which now has its own Hobby Horse Championships.

A few things worth sharing with the group: - One competitor featured, **Maisie Scaddon**, is a teenage **Hobby Horsing Gold Medallist** – this is taken seriously, with real medals and championships. - It's not just children – **adults compete too**, including at least one grown man shown jumping obstacles in the video. - Riders **name their hobbyhorses**, just like real horses – one competitor's horse is called "the Diva." - According to the video, hobbyhorsing costs roughly **a twentieth** of what real horse riding costs – no stables, no vet bills, no feed. - The video ends with the reporter trying it herself, jumping around the arena with a hobbyhorse of her own – a classic "I tried it" format.

Discussion questions

1. Is this a "real" sport, in your opinion? What makes something a sport – skill, competition, physical effort, all three?
2. Why do you think hobbyhorsing is popular mostly with teenage girls? Would you want to try it?
3. The video says it costs a twentieth of real riding. Does that change how seriously you take it?

Written exercises (10 min)

A. Vocabulary matching

Match each word to its meaning.

Words: dressage · show-jumping · championship · gold medallist · competitor · obstacle

Meanings (mixed up): A. someone who takes part in a competition B. a big competition to find the best C. a controlled, precise style of riding D. the person who

won first place E. something you jump over F. riding style focused on jumping over things

B. True or false

1. Hobbyhorsing started in the UK.
2. Only children compete in hobbyhorsing.
3. Maisie Scaddon is a Hobby Horsing Gold Medallist.
4. Hobbyhorsing costs about the same as real horse riding.
5. Riders give their hobbyhorses names.

C. Short writing

Write 4–5 sentences describing your own invented "not-quite-real" sport, the way this text describes hobbyhorsing: what equipment is used, where it started, who competes, and one surprising fact.

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Game: "Coach Says" - Hobbyhorse Edition

Same format as the original horse riding "Coach Says," but now everyone gets an imaginary (or improvised – a broom, a rolled-up jumper on a stick, whatever's on hand) hobbyhorse.

- One student is the coach, calling out commands from the horse riding vocabulary list: *walk on, trot on, halt, jump!*
- Only obey if preceded by "Coach says..." – otherwise freeze.
- **Extra twist:** set up 2–3 low obstacles (chairs, bags, cones) as a mini jumping course. On "Coach says jump!", everyone has to hop over the nearest obstacle while still "riding" their hobbyhorse. Genuinely closer to what real hobbyhorsers do, and should land well with a group that's already shown they like the physical, competitive side of these games.

Optional extension: in pairs, students design and name their own hobbyhorse (a quick sketch and a name is enough) and present it to the class in English – nice low-stakes speaking task, and it directly recycles the "the Diva" detail from the video.

About this activity

Standalone "fun fact" piece + game, ~15 min – ties back into the horse riding unit and "Coach Says"

A. Vocabulary matching

1. dressage-C, show-jumping-F, championship-B, gold medallist-D, competitor-A, obstacle-E

B. True or false

1. Hobbyhorsing started in the UK. → False – Finland
2. Only children compete in hobbyhorsing. → False – adults too
3. Maisie Scaddon is a Hobby Horsing Gold Medallist. → True
4. Hobbyhorsing costs about the same as real horse riding. → False – roughly a twentieth of the cost
5. Riders give their hobbyhorses names. → True